

HINDUSTAN SHIPYARD Established 1941

Having built 170 new vessels, repaired nearly 2,000 and now equipped to construct submarines, Hindustan Shipyard has Rs 2,000 crore worth of orders to build and repair merchant ships

MAKING WAVES

It is a prestigious and strategic facility that is poised to change hands again. It owes its origins to Walchand Hirachand, the then chairman of the Scindia Steam Navigation Company Limited. Born as the Scindia Shipyards in 1941, it was nationalised to be known as the Hindustan Shipyard Ltd (HSL) in 1961. Having emerged as the largest public sector shipyard, it is now set to be transferred from the Shipping to the Defence Ministry and in the custody of the Indian Navy.

The commencement of the pioneering shipbuilding yard symbolised the revival of the shipbuilding industry in its modern form in India,

which in the ancient times was among the foremost maritime countries. It owes its existence to the extraordinary vision of Hirachand, who fought a relentless battle against the discriminating government of the day. The foundation stone for the shipyard was laid by Rajendra Prasad in 1942, much before he became the first president of India.

HSL has built 170 new vessels and repaired nearly 2,000 so far. Its turnover is around Rs 500 crore, including Rs 150 crore that it earns on repair work. "Ours is not merely the oldest and the largest shipyard but one with the potential to build new

state-of-the-art vessels and even repair oil rigs and submarines," says Commodore Naresh Kumar, 59, chairman and managing director, HSL. Kumar has spent 10 of his 33 years as a naval officer at Indian shipyards.

Though its mainstay lies in merchant ship building, including bulk carriers, offshore patrol vessels, survey ships, drill ships, offshore platforms and repairing vessels for the Indian Navy, Shipping Corporation, Dredging Corporation and other sea faring entities, it is equipped to construct new medium and sophisticated submarines. As a result, repairs and major refits of submarines, which were done in Russia, are now carried out in Visakhapatnam. After the launch of Arihant, the country's first nuclear submarine earlier this year, decks have been cleared for the movement of HSL towards creating an indigenous capability to build nuclear submarines.

Being in the public sector with necessary infrastructure, including a covered shipbuilding dock, and expertise helped HSL clinch an order from the Indian Navy to rebuild a submarine and the navy, leveraging on this and

the Arihant, is keen on the takeover. The navy has announced plans to set up a new futuristic 5,000-acre base just 50 km away from HSL.

Driven by the recent surge in the shipping industry, the shipyard has Rs 2,000 crore worth of orders for merchant shipbuilding and repairs. The turnover has risen sharply from about Rs 150 crore four years ago to Rs 500 crore. This is why the Shipping Ministry wants to retain it to attend to the current orders as well as the work commissioned by the Defence Ministry, while the latter wants exclusive ownership. The Government offer to chip in with Rs 800 crore for its restructuring plan has queered the pitch further.

by Amarnath K. Menon

20th
is the global rank of India's fleet size, with 8.42 m gross tonnage and 1.19 per cent of the world fleet.

K BHASKAR RAO



Commodore Naresh Kumar 59, CMD

"Ours is the oldest and the largest shipyard with the potential to build state-of-the-art vessels and repair oil rigs and submarines."